

A/B Test Experiment Plan: Onboarding Flow Optimization

Status: Draft — Ready for Review **Owner:** [Your Name] **Team:** Growth / Product **Last Updated:** August 8, 2026

1. Executive Summary

We are losing a large number of new users during onboarding — before they even get to try the product. We believe this is because our current onboarding has **13 steps**, and every extra step gives a user another chance to give up and leave.

Right now, **60% of users who start onboarding actually finish it**. The industry standard for onboarding completion is around **80%**. That 20-point gap represents users we are actively losing today for a fixable reason — not because they don't want the product, but because the path to get to it is too long.

This document proposes a test comparing our current 13-step flow against two shorter versions (7 steps and 5 steps) to find out how much of that gap we can close, and what it's worth to the business in real revenue — **without spending a single extra dollar on marketing or user acquisition**.

2. Business Context

We run a B2C mobile app that uses AI to teach English. Onboarding is the very first thing a new user experiences — before they've seen any real value from the product. If we lose people here, we've often already paid to acquire them (through ads, referrals, etc.), so this drop-off is pure wasted spend.

Our current onboarding flow has **13 sequential steps** (e.g., setting a learning goal, taking a level assessment, turning on notifications, creating an account, answering personalization questions, and more) before a user reaches the actual product.

3. Problem Statement, In Plain Terms

Think of onboarding like a line of 13 doors a new user has to walk through before they get to the classroom. Every door is a chance for them to turn around and leave. The more doors we ask people to walk through, the more people we lose along the way — regardless of how excited they were to download the app.

Current situation:

Metric	Our Current Number	Industry Standard
Onboarding completion rate (% of users who finish onboarding)	60%	~80%
Completed onboarding → paid conversion rate	6%	~6% (in line with industry)

The important insight here: **our conversion rate of paid users is already healthy and matches the industry**. The problem isn't that our product or pricing is failing to convert people — it's that too many people never even make it far enough to be counted. If we simply let more people *reach* the point where our normal 6% conversion rate can kick in, we grow revenue with zero extra acquisition spend.

4. What This Is Costing Us — In Dollars

(The numbers below use illustrative example figures — monthly new users and average revenue per paying user — so the math is easy to follow. Please swap in our actual numbers before sharing this externally; the calculation logic stays the same.)

Assumptions used for this example: - New users entering onboarding per month: **100,000** - Average monthly revenue per paying user: **\$30**

Where we are today:

Step	Value
Users who start onboarding	100,000
Onboarding completion rate	60%
Users who finish onboarding	60,000
Paid conversion rate (unchanged)	6%
Paying users per month	3,600
Monthly revenue	\$108,000

If we close the gap to the industry standard (80% completion), with no other changes:

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Step	Value
Users who start onboarding	100,000
Onboarding completion rate	80%
Users who finish onboarding	80,000
Paid conversion rate (unchanged)	6%
Paying users per month	4,800
Monthly revenue	\$144,000

Bottom line: closing this gap is worth an estimated **+\$36,000 in monthly revenue**, or roughly **+\$432,000 per year** — from the exact same number of users we already have, with no increase in ad spend or acquisition cost. This is the number this experiment is designed to help us capture.

5. Hypothesis

We believe that reducing the number of onboarding steps from 13 will reduce the number of people who quit partway through, **which will result in** more users completing onboarding and reaching the point where they can experience the product, **as measured by** onboarding completion rate, activation rate, and paid conversion rate.

Important assumption we want to test, not just assume: we're betting that it's the *number* of steps causing people to leave — not the *content* of any one specific step (like a confusing question or a slow screen). The design below helps us tell the difference.

6. Experiment Design

6.1 Overview

Experiment type	3-way test — users randomly shown one of three onboarding versions
Who gets randomized	Each individual new user, right when they first open the app
Traffic split	Equal thirds — about 33% of users see each version
Platform	Both iOS and Android, balanced across the test

6.2 The Three Versions Being Tested

Version	Description	Number of Steps
A — Control (current experience)	Our existing onboarding, unchanged	13 steps
B — Medium version	A trimmed flow that keeps the most important steps and removes or combines the rest	7 steps
C — Short version	A minimal flow with only what's absolutely necessary before a user can start learning	5 steps

6.3 How We Decide What to Cut

Instead of just picking the first few steps, we'll sort all 13 current steps into three buckets: - **Must-have:** Needed before we can create an account or personalize lessons (e.g., account creation, level check) - **Can wait:** Useful but not essential right away — can be asked later, once the user already sees value (e.g., notification permission, detailed goals) - **Nice-to-have / combinable:** Can be merged into another screen or removed with minimal loss

This way, if the shorter flows win, we'll know *which* steps were actually safe to cut — not just that "shorter is better."

7. How We'll Know If It Worked (Success Metrics)

7.1 Main Metric We Care About Most

Metric	What It Means	Why It's the Headline Number
Onboarding completion rate	Out of everyone who starts onboarding, what % actually finish it	This directly tells us whether shorter onboarding reduces people quitting

7.2 Supporting Metrics

Metric	What It Means	Why We Track It
Activation rate	% of users who finish onboarding AND go on to complete their first lesson	Makes sure people aren't just finishing onboarding faster, but actually getting into the product
Return rate (Day 1 / Day 7)	% of users who come back to the app 1 day / 7 days later	Confirms the users we're keeping are genuinely interested, not just rushed through
Paid conversion rate	% of activated users who become paying subscribers	Connects the experiment directly back to revenue
Time to first lesson	How long it takes a new user to reach their first real lesson	A direct measure of how much friction we removed

7.3 Metrics We Must Not Let Get Worse (Guardrails)

These are checks to make sure that in trying to fix one problem, we don't accidentally create a new one.

Guardrail Metric	Why It Matters	What Could Go Wrong Without It
Lesson relevance / personalization quality	Fewer onboarding questions means less information to personalize lessons	Users get generic content that doesn't fit their level or goals, and quietly churn later
Day 30 return rate	Are users still around a month later?	A shorter onboarding could attract people who complete it easily but were never serious learners
Refund / cancellation rate	Are paying users asking for money back?	Rushing people through onboarding might mean they don't fully understand what they signed up for
Support ticket volume (onboarding-related)	Are people confused or complaining?	A skipped step (like explaining permissions or billing) could create confusion we didn't have before
Notification opt-in rate	% of users who allow app notifications	If this step gets removed/delayed, it could hurt our ability to bring users back later

8. Events We Need to Track

To measure this experiment properly, our analytics/engineering team needs to log the following events. This is the shopping list for what needs to be instrumented before the test starts.

Funnel & Onboarding Events - `app_installed` — user installs the app - `onboarding_started` — user begins onboarding (start of the funnel) - `onboarding_step_viewed` — logged every time a user sees a step (include step number, step name, and which test version they're in) - `onboarding_step_completed` — user successfully completes a step - `onboarding_step_abandoned` — user leaves/exits mid-step (tells us exactly where people drop off) - `onboarding_completed` — user finishes the entire flow - `account_created` — user creates an account/profile

Product Engagement Events - `first_lesson_started` — user begins their first lesson (this is our activation trigger point) - `first_lesson_completed` — user finishes their first lesson (this is our "activation" success event) - `app_opened_day1` / `app_opened_day7` / `app_opened_day30` — return visits, used for retention metrics - `notification_permission_shown` / `notification_permission_accepted` / `notification_permission_denied`

Monetization Events - `trial_started` — user begins a free trial (if applicable) - `subscription_purchased` — user converts to a paying subscriber (our paid conversion event) - `subscription_cancelled` — user cancels - `refund_requested` — user requests a refund

Quality & Guardrail Events - `app_crash` / `app_error` — technical issues during onboarding or the app in general - `support_ticket_created` — logged with a tag for whether it's onboarding-related (may come from support tooling rather than the app itself) - `lesson_feedback_submitted` — if we collect any in-app rating of lesson relevance/quality

Every event above should also record: which test version (A/B/C) the user is in, platform (iOS/Android), and timestamp — so we can slice all results by test group.